

RAVEESH KR

**METHIL DEVIKA**
*Classical Dancer*

# MUSIC FOR THE DEAF

## Dancer Methil Devika blends **sign language with *mudras***, creating a novel performance for her differently abled audience

**By JEEMON JACOB**

**Last month, Indian classical dance witnessed a path-breaking moment in Thiruvananthapuram. As Mohiniyattam exponent Methil Devika started her performance at the Ammaveedu, a heritage hub of music and dance, an excited group of hearing- and speech-impaired fans immersed themselves in the spectacle unfolding before them. But how did they follow the show? Devika merged Indian sign language with the *hasta mudras* (hand gestures) of classical dance for her performance titled 'Crossover', under her visionary project 'Dance Philanthropy and Social Inclusion'.**

As expected, it got instant acclaim and more such performances are now planned. Additionally, a short film on 'Crossover' will soon grace various venues in Kerala. Devika says she reluctantly took on a role in a Malayalam film, *Katha Innuvare* (The Story Till Now), to fund the initiative.

In her illustrious three-decade career, the dancer has thrived as a dancer, researcher and curator, captivating art enthusiasts all over the world. Yet, her current endeavour holds special significance. "During the Covid epidemic, with no stage and performances, I visualised a dance form I hoped would resonate with the less fortunate," says Devika. The breakthrough came with the idea to transcend the confines of *mudras*, communicating through the language. "I learned sign language to connect with their hearts," says the dancer.

Born in Palakkad into a family deeply rooted in the arts, Devika was introduced to classical dancing at the age of four. She has been holding solo performances since she was 20. "What's the purpose of dance if it has limitations and the art can only reach the privileged? As an artist, I feel a responsibility to curate performances for the underprivileged," shares an elated Devika.

Through her performances, Devika has demonstrated that dance transcends the boundaries of speech and sound. In Thiruvananthapuram, she observed that a few people in the audience were mimicking her *mudras*. "It was a delightful experience. I've performed all over the world, in front of people of diverse nationalities and languages, but witnessing an audience embody my *mudras* is unprecedented. It's a sign that my performance touched their hearts. I feel my mission is fulfilled," says the dancer, closing her eyes with contentment. ■

**HAPPINESS QUOTIENT**

- **The dancer's 'Dance Philanthropy and Social Inclusion' initiative has created classical dance performances for the differently abled**
- **She got the idea during the Covid lockdown when there were no recitals**